Tab 1

Invisible Disabilities

Sudiksha Aalori

Feb 9, 2026

3 min read

Updated: Apr 10, 2026

A challenge I have learned to coexist with throughout my entire life is palmar hyperhidrosis: a condition characterized by excessive sweating of the hands in circumstances where my body does not have a physiological purpose for it.

Awkward handshakes, soggy notebook papers, and smudged fingerprint scans have plagued me in ways that most people will never have to think about. Drying my pens and pencils, wearing vinyl gloves while cooking, and constantly having to wipe my hands against my pants is at best embarrassing, and at worst, hindering. My mother, who had hyperhidrosis when she was younger, has long since physiologically outgrown it and forgotten what it was like. I have never met anyone else who is like me.

Hyperhidrosis is obscure to the general population. I don't explain it to many. I offer first bumps instead of high-fives, and I perpetually keep a jacket on me to slide the sleeve under my hand

when I’m writing. I grab an extra stack of napkins when I’m eating at a restaurant, and I wear
weightlifting gloves when I’m at the gym. I have found ways to circumvent my issues. I have
discovered alternatives and accommodations where they are applicable. My problems never
disappear, but they can almost always be mitigated.

When people think of the term “disability”, they usually think of something that is visible to the
eye. When it comes to physical disabilities, wheelchairs are a commonly depicted symbol. We
see the handicap icon in places such as parking lots, public bathrooms, and automatically
opening doors. When it comes to neurological disorders, however, things are often less obvious.

But while people may not be able to spot neurological conditions in an individual right away,
usually they’ll have some sort of background knowledge about them. Cerebral palsy, epilepsy,
and autism spectrum disorder are all diagnoses we are generally familiar with.

Whether something is considered a disability or not highly depends on the individual who has it.
Because we all come from different walks of life, and symptoms of conditions can present

themselves very differently from one person to the next, the severity of an affliction is subjective.
For me, I hesitate to call my hyperhidrosis a disability, but I definitely think that there are many
aspects of my social, personal, and professional life that it affects negatively.

Because of my experiences, I am very open-minded towards the struggles of others. When
people use the terms “equity” and “privilege”, they usually mention them in the context of
race/ethnicity or social class. However, I believe that these terms can be applied to a lot more
than that. There are infinite aspects within life that someone can be disadvantaged in, even if
they are well-off in other ways.

Compassion is a learned skill, and it’s a tool I wield everyday. There are already enough
challenges that affect us in our everyday lives that performing acts of kindness, no matter how
small they may be, can go a long way. Being kind costs nothing, and it’s one of the easiest and
most effective forms of positivity one can offer to the world. I never assume to know what
someone is going through, but I always make sure to be understanding regardless. I know my
contribution will be meaningful to somebody out there, and for me, that is more than enough of a

reason to do it.

Tab 2

Literacy

Nelly Awad

Jan 30, 2026

2 min read

Updated: Apr 10, 2026

Pencil lead smeared on paper. Solid black pixels arranged on a screen. Words are the channel
of ideas; language is the essence of communication. Nobody remembers anything from their
early infancy due to the lack of language. Without language, thoughts cannot be formed, and in
turn, memories fail to be made. Conversely, the more language one has, the more ideas can be
crafted, and the further concretized a recollection will be.

And that's the allure of it all, isn't it? 6,500 different languages across the world, and yet more
can be counted if considering various dialects. Over six thousand five hundred separate ways to
communicate, and more can be counted if considering nonverbal methods. Every single person
on this planet interacts, exchanges, and connects with others. Every single person finds their
own way of doing so.

I grew up speaking to my family in our native language: Hakka, a dialect of Chinese. After I

entered the school system, I picked up on English. Neither of these two languages are more or
less meaningful than the other—they are simply different. Being bilingual has broadened the
world for me; it has taught me the importance of countless cultures and how to appreciate the
variation between them. It has taught me how to relay my thoughts in different formats so I can
reach a wider audience.

If I didn't have language, I would have nothing. It's no wonder that I save journals dating back to
first grade. Ever since I've known how to read, I've known how to write. Poetry and narratives,
memoirs and anecdotes—I write to record my thoughts. I lay them out on a canvas and
assemble scenes from the same set of 26 letters I learned in kindergarten, painting landscapes
and constructing stages from my bank of knowledge.

I expand on my stories, overhaul them, and begin new ones all the time. Again and again, I view
writing as a familiar face—something I can turn to as a first resort. I write to reflect and I write to
escape. I write out of obligation and I write out of free will. I write because I can, because it's
accessible, because I have the privilege to.

I write because it’s meaningful, and because it is an integral part of me that has largely shaped
the way I assimilate the world. To me, literacy is the gift that keeps giving.

Tab 3

Matcha

Naledi Khumalo

Jan 19, 2026
3 min read
Updated: Apr 10, 2026

As early as I can remember, my answer to the question “what’s your favorite color?” was
indubitably, wholeheartedly “purple.”

I sometimes addressed the color by different monikers, varying in sophistication, as I grew up. I
occasionally chose different shades of the same hue. In elementary school, it was light purple or
pastel purple. In high school, it was lilac, lavender, or mauve.

I loved seeing the purple that appeared in streaks across the expanse of the sky mid-sunset. I
loved amethysts, asters, and jellyfish.

My favorite color seemed so set in stone that I thought the foundations of that opinion would
never crack. My favorite food, animal, and number would morph and evolve over time, as I
associated them with different memories and experiences throughout my life. Those answers

were transient and capricious, but I never thought that these descriptors would come to apply to
my favorite color as well.

My childhood neighborhood had cookie-cutter houses. The HOA provided a predetermined list
of approved colors to paint the exterior walls. My house was a muted yellow, simple and
unremarkable. I never gave it much thought. To me, it wasn't the worst option, but it wasn't the
best either.

My sister and I routinely went on long bike rides around the neighborhood. Its perimeter hardly
measured a mile, but we cycled in repeated loops. We would go around and around, for hours
at a time, stopping by the kids' playground and the community pool, picking up bougainvillea
petals and coins and stray toys forgotten on the street.

We would point at the house in the corner with the largest backyard and call it a mansion. We
rated the seasonal decorations of every decked out home, pitching them against one another as
if it was a competition. We commented on the fonts of all the house numbers, and judged the
custom brick patterns of different driveways.

There were houses painted blue and houses painted pink. I didn't like the khaki or beige
shades. I thought the orange was merely okay.

The green homes were my favorite. They were the shade of olive and sage – like an opaque
peridot. The color was reminiscent of the green tea I would brew in my mug and add milk and
sugar to.

I made my green tea the way my grandmother taught me to when I was twelve. I didn't know it
back then, but it was an approximation of a matcha latte – a DIY version with the ingredients I
already had in the house.

Years later, after moving out, I would buy the occasional matcha latte when I stopped by the
Starbucks on my college campus, or when I fueled my car at the Wawa by my apartment before
embarking on the four hour commute back to my hometown.

I got matcha boba from local shops with my peers after our monthly meetings at the Asian
Student Association. I tried matcha ice cream for the first time at a dessert store downtown after
spending an afternoon at the mall.

It wasn't until I made a new friend at my university's run club that I began considering buying matcha powder to use at home. My friend introduced me to the various qualities of matcha available, ranging from the cheap kinds that are sold at the grocery store, all the way to hojicha – a roasted green tea with a rich, earthy flavor.

As a Chinese American woman, I grew up with tea in my everyday life. Whether it was black tea, oolong, or chrysanthemum, my family typically brewed and consumed it as it is, without any sweeteners or add-ins. I had plenty of green tea in my childhood, but never true matcha. It's one of the few things I picked up in my adulthood.

Matcha originated in China around the 7th century, but it is commonly associated with Japanese culture in the modern time. Japan is where my friend and I obtain imported matcha powder from, and between our pre-workout caffeine doses and our mid-study session boba treats, we acknowledge the history and culture behind our favorite beverage, and how it has brought us together the same way it has done for many others.

Preferences and opinions are always subject to change, and somewhere in the middle of being

a moody teenager and a college student figuring out her future, I found myself responding
“matcha” to inquiries about my favorite color. It pinpoints the exact shade of green I want to
convey, and it’s an answer that gives an insight into who I am as an individual.

It’s the perfect icebreaker for people who want to get to know me.

Tab 4

Segregation Now: The Lost Legacy of Education Post-Brown (Part 2)

Steve Wang

Dec 1, 2025

5 min read

To Fort Bend's credit, there were no stories of George Wallace standing in a doorway or enraged white families berating black students chanting for the reimplementation of segregation. It really could have been a lot worse, this was a time when entire school districts were being shut down just to deny Black students their new constitutional right to an equal education. FBISD never even had to be sued into integrating. Admittedly, their 1965 initiative to integrate came after a more equivocal proposal was denied by the federal government, but overall, it seemed that the unitary school system I attend today emerged out of a willingness to cooperate with the changing tides. I'm sure this is the narrative of desegregation the district administration likes to hear, that it was clean and simple.

Strangely enough, when Stafford residents within FBISD voted to break away and form Stafford Municipal School District in 1977, Fort Bend took a very different stance on the existence of racism within their school hallways. The litigation that ensued from FBISD's dispute of this breakaway made for some of the most surreal court opinions I have ever seen. Unwilling to let go of the Stafford residents under its umbrella and fearful of a similar separatist movement growing within Sugar Land parents, Fort Bend and its superintendent, Lawrence Elkins took to the stand to argue that the racism was still too present throughout the district, and the secession of the Stafford residents would impede FBISD's Constitutional duty to desegregate its schools.

Mr. Elkins stated: "I think that we probably encouraged [some of the black teachers] in their own minds to retire because what was happening was just as visible to them as anyone else." He also admitted that the "end result" of the district's practices during this period was that black teachers were encouraged to resign in order to avoid demotion or were demoted because they were black.

Reading the lawsuit feels like you've been transported to an alternate universe where post Brown v Board, southern districts were actually very keenly aware of the ways in which structural racism lingers in school systems even though they might ostensibly be integrated or neutral. It quickly became very clear that it wasn't as if the district was incapable of acknowledging how racism in the school system didn't just end at Brown v. Board, they were very much capable of sending their superintendent into a court of law to testify as much. It was only when their power and reach was being challenged that they put in the effort to bring it into broad daylight.

I have never seen a district so desperately try to convince a court that "oh my god we're so racist we need you to step in and make sure we're not racist." The Fifth Circuit court of appeals eventually ruled against FBISD, overturning the previous district court decision.

"Under these circumstances, we think it clear that FBISD has made, at least since 1973, the type of sustained good faith effort to recruit minority faculty members so as to remedy the effects of any past discriminatory practices… Try as it may, FBISD cannot deny its success."

This conclusion is far from unfounded, the district employed several integration methods, including putting new schools in between white and black communities so that they could be zoned to the same school.

See look right here, “The Board of Trustees did not place an elementary school in the center of the Quail Valley subdivision in order to avoid creating a one-race school.”

But like, I *went* one of the schools they’re talking about here; it’s a middle school now. It’s also one of the most blatantly segregated places I’ve ever been in. Sure when you look at the raw data, it almost looks like a dream distribution, but the reality of the Gifted and Talented program there is that it essentially creates two schools in the same building. As a GT student, I was literally physically separated from the zoned children every day, and since we’d almost never have to interact with the other side of the school, I saw the same division and racist thought processes that Jim Crow segregation engendered in white kids. It was in the way they used “non-GT” as a proto-slur. It was in the stories of admins assuming Black GT students were in the wrong place on their way to class.

Now, this fact no longer surprises me. Gifted and talented programs and their academy counterparts owe their roots to some pretty explicit efforts to separate out white children. Here’s Norm Fruchter, a former New York City school board member, talking about why his district decided to implement a gifted program.

“The district started the [gifted] program explicitly to maintain a white population."

Even when they’re not packaged into academy-exclusive classes, we still deny students of color access to all kinds of spaces for subtle but pervasive reasons. Sometimes all it takes is a counselor trying to advise you out of taking that advanced

math course. Then, because the gap between AP and regular classes is so big, trying to take an advanced course the next year is nigh impossible. The foundation just isn't there. If they don't think you can, then you won't, and if you won't, then you'll never. To my peers in Multivariable Calculus or Organic Chemistry, ask yourself, how many black or hispanic students are in my class?

You may notice I didn't just say "students of color" there, and for good reason. Especially in a district like Fort Bend ISD, you can't ignore the Asian population. And thats,,, a little harder to reconcile, right? We have a very different place in this historical context. This could be a whole other video, but what we need to remember is the existence of the model minority myth. Asians were not always this welcome into polite society, and only when Asian immigrants started being selected for preexisting wealth and quality education did the narrative shift from yellow peril to "be more like them." Regardless, Asians are a huge part of the community. At Dulles High, we're 40.3% of the student body. Many of us, and many non-Asians as well, are the children of foreign born immigrants.

I think that's a huge part of the reason it's so easy for us to forget about the history right in front of our eyes. Our communities are new, they weren't around to witness Jim Crow or Brown. My grandma was worried about the Great Leap Forward, not segregation. So, these events are abstracted away into our history textbooks, a paragraph of a chapter in a textbook you only open to study for the test tomorrow only to forget in a week. It's far too easy to miss the human impact of every sentence and allow our state-mandated rose tinted glasses to cloud our vision.

Remember those two protests I told you about? The Freedom Day Boycott has a wikipedia article, youtube videos, and countless articles praising its bravery and steadfastness. The white parents are far less remembered today, even though they

were the ones who ended up actually changing policy in the end. The direction we've always been going in, the way our societal inertia points, is much harder to learn about, much more difficult to encounter precisely because its assumed. We still see segregation in our schools, its just in the form of a GT program or a disciplinary suspension. Just because the word racism remains unsaid does not mean it doesn't linger in our schools.

If you care about equity, then you have to know that the fight for equality was never easy, it didn't happen overnight, and it certainly didn't come in the form of one-off social movements. Justice is locked behind decades of hard, persistent demonstrations and political participation. If you care about understanding our current government and its relationship to its citizens, you have to remember that the real history is hard to find. You won't see it on your instagram feed or in your textbooks or on some district information webpage. The revolution will not be televised.

Tab 5

Modern Femininity



Hari Nair

Oct 30, 2025

3 min read

I could never scream.

I chalk it up to being raised in debate. In such a male-dominated activity, I learned to wield silence at the risk of losing a ballot: don't be too loud or the judge will think you're hysterical; talk less, smile more. When you speak at 300 words-per-minute, use a deep timbre, as masculine as possible. I go into every round on a high, but inevitably, when I'm downed for being "angry" and "aggressive" while my male counterparts are "empathetic" and "passionate," I muffle my sobs in a bathroom stall.

I love debate fiercely, so I smothered myself with silence, policing my voice until I internalized judgment. That was my mindset as I arrived at Texas Girls State, expecting a week of tense political discourse, humorless and adversarial like debate—so imagine my shock finding a boisterous auditorium of 600 raucous girls singing "my-ma-was-born-in-DAL-LAS, fa-ther-in-FORT-WORTH." It was like being pulled to Barbieland: songs breaking out at political party meetings, dance parties every night. *Is this empowering*, I wondered, *or just embarrassing?*

Confession time: I'm a terrible singer. Years of dodging the mic at karaoke had permanently clogged up my throat. Nevertheless, something stirred that I hadn't even realized I'd longed for. It started with a simple offer to make campaign posters with my direct rival, something unthinkable in debate. *She can't be serious*, I protested. But

as we chatted about education policy, drawing out serious platforms with copious amounts of glitter, I realized I'd misjudged.

Conversations blossomed, and with each new friendship, I allowed more of myself to surface—
bravely-fighting-social-anxiety Barbie, like Emma;
proudly-embracing-her-bisexuality Barbie, like Mila;
advocate-for-first-gen-immigrants Barbie, like Jennifer.
They belted the lyrics freely, and at their side, I found myself singing louder.

By the day of my governor's speech, throats were raw. It was pouring rain, the auditorium was freezing, and Girls State was singing: loud, messy, and perfect.

I step to the podium, palms sweaty as I confront a sea of bright skirts and dark pantsuits, pixie cuts and french braids. My debate voice whispers: *You barely know these girls. Just stop. You're embarrassing.*

I grab the mic.

"When I first got here," I begin, hoping my voice isn't shaking, "all the singing seemed pretty silly to me. I was afraid you would judge me, so I shut myself up." Heads swivel; giggles ripple through the crowd.

"But, shoot, we're all embarrassed. Everything is embarrassing. That's what's powerful at Girls State—here, we embrace that everything because we *are* everything: emotional, angry, stubborn, embarrassing." Cheers erupt, rumbling encouragement.

“It wasn’t the singing that was silly, it was I for muting myself. So I say, sing. Be cringe. Because that’s not all we are.” I grip the podium; my voice rises. “We are powerful, assertive, LOUD women, and we shall NOT be silenced.”

Girls State *screams*.

My inhibitions disintegrated. And I screamed back: for Emma and Mila, for Jennifer and every girl brave enough to demand to be heard. I screamed until I lost my voice, then screamed some more. When the winning candidate ran through the human tunnel, beaming brighter than I’ve ever seen, we screamed as one, loving without fear, crying out in power, vulnerability, and no-strings-attached kindness.

After Girls State, my world is louder. I pulled my friends to karaoke night at Kenyon, assaulting their eardrums with my off-key Hamilton. I surveyed debaters to pierce the silence around toxic competition and gatekeeping in our community and broadcast my clarion call in a defiant podcast. When chants of “F*ck-the-Fra-ming” filled the dining hall at NSD camp and strangers thanked me because “everyone knew these problems existed, but no one voiced them before,” I knew my shouts had been heard.

Two months after Girls State, I visited the US Capitol. The Senate Chamber was whisper-quiet, eerily so. I can already imagine myself there.

But for now—

I drop my jaw
and

SCREAM.